SECURITY IRELAND POLICY CHECKLIST

Ireland's Security & Defence Architecture

What Every EU State Has. What Ireland Has. What's Missing.

A systematic comparison of the institutional frameworks, strategies, and capabilities that comparable EU member states maintain as standard — measured against what Ireland has in place, what is partially developed, and what does not exist. Updated April 2026 to reflect the National Maritime Security Strategy (March 2026) and cross-referenced against the Updated Detailed Implementation Plan for the Commission on the Defence Forces (February 2026).

Security Ireland

April 2026

Strategic frameworks

The foundational documents and institutional structures that define how a state organises its security and defence.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
National security strategy	MISSING	In development since 2019. Seven years later, unpublished. Every comparable EU state has one.
National defence policy / white paper	PARTIAL	White Paper on Defence 2015 is outdated. Defence Policy Review published July 2024; Strategic Framework 2026 published February 2026. CoDF (2022) is advisory, not policy. No single current white paper.
Dedicated Minister for Defence	MISSING	Defence is held jointly with Foreign Affairs and Trade. Not a standalone portfolio. Unique among larger EU states.
National Security Committee (standing)	PARTIAL	Exists but meets irregularly. No permanent secretariat. Chaired by Sec Gen of Dept of Taoiseach.
National Security Analysis Centre	PARTIAL	NSAC established 2019 under Dept of Taoiseach. Understaffed. No independent analytical capability.
Defence industrial policy	MISSING	No framework for Irish industry participation in EU defence programmes. Enterprise Ireland historically restricted from dual-use.
Security clearance system	PARTIAL	Interim system introduced 2025/2026 to allow Irish firms to bid for EU defence contracts. Not yet comprehensive.
Defence attaché network	NEW 2025+	Pilot programme 2026: London, Paris, Washington. Most EU states have maintained these for decades.

Intelligence & threat assessment

The institutional architecture for gathering, analysing, and disseminating security intelligence.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Unified national intelligence agency	MISSING	Intelligence split between military (J2/IMIS), police (Garda CSB), and cyber (NCSC). No unified agency. Unique in Europe.
Integrated threat assessment capability	PARTIAL	NSAC produces some assessments but is not a standing analytical agency with independent collection capability.
Foreign intelligence service	MISSING	No equivalent of MI6, DGSE, BND. Ireland has no foreign intelligence collection capability.
Counter-intelligence capability	PARTIAL	Garda CSB performs some functions. No dedicated counter-intelligence agency. Under-resourced for the threat level.
Parliamentary oversight of intelligence	MISSING	No equivalent of UK Intelligence and Security Committee or German Parlamentarisches Kontrollgremium.

Airspace & air defence

The capability to monitor and defend sovereign airspace.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Primary radar coverage	NEW 2025+	Procurement underway (2025–2027). Until now, Ireland had no primary military radar. Unique in Europe.
Fighter / air intercept capability	MISSING	No fighter aircraft. No plan to acquire. RAF intercepts unknown aircraft in Irish airspace under unpublished arrangement.
Surface-to-air missile capability	MISSING	None. No short, medium, or long-range air defence.
Counter-drone / counter-UAS capability	NEW 2025+	Being procured after Zelenskyy drone incident (Dec 2025). Portugal provided capability for that event. Delivery targeted September 2026 per CoDF implementation plan.
Air sovereignty declared and enforced	MISSING	Airspace is sovereign in law but not enforced in practice. Ireland cannot intercept, identify, or compel compliance.

Maritime security

The capability to monitor and protect 880,000 km² of maritime zone — the largest in Western Europe.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
National maritime security strategy	IN PLACE	Published March 2026. Six strategic objectives, 41 action items to 2030. Whole-of-government approach led by Dept of Defence. Rolling action plan with annual reporting.
Armed naval vessels	MISSING	Naval Service vessels are not armed for combat. No anti-ship, anti-submarine, or area-denial capability.
Anti-submarine warfare capability	MISSING	None. Towed sonar procurement underway (CAPTAS) but no ASW weapons or trained capability.
Subsea cable monitoring capability	MISSING	No standing monitoring of cables carrying 90% of transatlantic data. Reliant on allied notification.
Sufficient vessels to patrol EEZ	MISSING	Eight vessels, typically four operational. Cannot sustain continuous patrol of full maritime zone.
Naval Service at establishment strength	MISSING	807 personnel against establishment. Recruitment and retention crisis. Cannot crew all vessels.

Cyber security

The institutional capability to defend against cyber threats to state, critical infrastructure, and economy.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
National cyber security strategy (current)	MISSING	2019–2024 strategy expired. No published replacement. Defence Forces Cyber Defence Strategy published June 2024, but no whole-of-government national strategy. NIS2 requires member states to adopt one.
Resourced national cyber security centre	PARTIAL	NCSC exists but widely assessed as under-resourced for threat level. HSE attack (2021) demonstrated vulnerability.
Offensive cyber capability	MISSING	No capability. Netherlands, France, Germany, and others are moving to proactive/offensive cyber posture.
Cyber resilience certification framework	PARTIAL	Ireland participates in EU ECCF but national implementation is early stage.
PESCO cyber project participation	IN PLACE	Ireland participates in Cyber Threats and Incident Response PESCO project.

Energy security

The institutional architecture to ensure energy supply resilience during disruption.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Energy security strategy	MISSING	None. Government responds reactively to each crisis. No standing analytical or planning capability.
Gas storage	MISSING	Zero. Only EU member state with no gas storage. Corrib depleting (2027). 100% import dependency approaching.
LNG terminal	MISSING	No operational terminal. FSRU approved March 2025 but not yet built or operational.
Oil refining capacity	MISSING	Whitegate ceased independent operations. Ireland imports finished fuel products.
Standing energy crisis management unit	MISSING	Ad hoc Oil Security of Supply Group. No permanent staff, no threat assessment, no pre-agreed protocols.
Modern fuel crisis legislation	MISSING	Fuels (Control of Supplies) Act 1971, amended 1982. Pre-dates EEC membership, internet, and first oil crisis.
Strategic reserve repatriation	PARTIAL	28% of NORA stocks held abroad. Policy to repatriate exists (2015 White Paper) but not implemented at pace.

Civil crisis management & public order

The institutional capability to manage domestic crises without resorting to military deployment.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Gendarmerie / intermediate public order force	MISSING	Nothing between An Garda Síochána and the Defence Forces. FR, IT, ES, NL, PT, PL, RO all have gendarmeries.
Civil protection agency (standing)	MISSING	No equivalent of French Sécurité civile or German THW. Ad hoc coordination only.
National emergency management agency	MISSING	National Emergency Coordination Group is ad hoc. No permanent staff, no standing authority.
Proportionality test for military deployment	MISSING	No statutory test. Defence Act 1954 provides broad authority with no proportionality requirement.
Graduated escalation protocol	MISSING	No defined escalation sequence from policing to military. Binary switch: Gardí or army.
Parliamentary oversight of domestic deployment	MISSING	No Dáil notification or review requirement for aid to the civil power operations.
Domestic rules of engagement (published)	MISSING	ROE exist for overseas peacekeeping. No published ROE for domestic deployment against civilians.
Independent oversight of military conduct	MISSING	GSOC covers Garda conduct. No equivalent body for military conduct during domestic operations.
Ministerial accountability for crisis mgmt	MISSING	No minister owns crisis management. Falls between Justice and Defence.

Critical infrastructure protection

The framework for identifying, protecting, and ensuring resilience of critical national infrastructure.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Critical infrastructure protection legislation	PARTIAL	CER Directive transposition underway. National framework under development. Not yet operational.
Critical infrastructure registry	PARTIAL	Being developed under CER. No comprehensive registry currently published.
Standing infrastructure protection capability	MISSING	No dedicated force or unit. Ad hoc military deployment when crisis arrives (e.g. fuel depots, April 2026).
Subsea infrastructure protection framework	PARTIAL	Maritime Security Strategy (2026) addresses this. Implementation not yet begun.

Defence Forces capability

The state of Ireland's military capability against the Commission on Defence Forces benchmarks.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Personnel at establishment strength	MISSING	7,756 against current establishment of 9,739. Shortfall of ~2,000. LOA 2 target is 11,500. Government acknowledges current targets unreachable at present recruitment rates.
Commission on Defence Forces implementation	PARTIAL	54 of 130 recommendations completed after 4 years. Updated implementation plan published February 2026 with timelines to 2028. 76 recommendations remain; 22 due in 2026, 17 in 2027, 16 in 2028, 4 post-2028. Delivery against schedule remains to be demonstrated.
LOA 2 capability achieved	MISSING	Government committed to LOA 2 by 2028. Updated implementation plan published February 2026 with detailed timelines across five strategic objectives. Whether the institutional transformation required can be delivered within these timelines is undemonstrated. Key enablers — C2 legislation, force design, personnel growth — remain in early stages.
Defence spending at EU average	MISSING	~0.3% GDP vs EU average 1.9%. Lowest in EU. Record €1.49bn allocation for 2026 (34% increase since 2022) with €1.7bn capital under NDP 2025–2030. Still far below peers.
SAFE loan applications	MISSING	Ireland has not applied for any SAFE loans. 16 member states approved. Ireland chairs the distribution.

Democratic governance of security

The mechanisms that ensure democratic accountability and transparency in security and defence.

Framework / Policy	Ireland	Detail
Constitutional protection of neutrality	MISSING	Neutrality is policy, not constitutional. No constitutional provision. Seville Declaration attached to Lisbon Treaty.
Annual Dáil review of security commitments	MISSING	No annual review mechanism for overseas deployments, PESCO commitments, or bilateral arrangements.
Transparency requirement for Shannon	MISSING	No reporting requirement for military transits through Shannon Airport. Usage documented by campaigners, not state.
Parliamentary reporting on PESCO	MISSING	No formal reporting mechanism to Dáil on Ireland's 7 PESCO projects or binding commitments.
Published bilateral defence agreements	PARTIAL	Cork MoU (2026) publicly announced. RAF airspace arrangement remains unpublished.

S U M M A R Y

32	10	5	2
MISSING	PARTIAL	NEW (2025+)	IN PLACE

Of 49 security and defence frameworks assessed, Ireland has 2 fully in place, 10 partially developed, 5 newly initiated since 2025, and **32 missing entirely**. The pattern is consistent across every domain: strategic frameworks, intelligence, airspace, maritime, cyber, energy, crisis management, critical infrastructure, and democratic governance. The institutional architecture of a modern European security state has not been built.

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